

Case Study : *"Our Lady of the Nile"* (Notre-Dame du Nil) by Scholastique Mukasonga.

Published in 2012, this novel is a haunting exploration of the racial and political tensions in Rwanda during the 1970s that would eventually lead to the 1994 genocide.

I. Context and Setting

The novel is set in **1979** (15 years before the genocide) at the **Lycée Notre-Dame du Nil**, a prestigious Catholic boarding school for girls. The school is perched high in the mountains, close to the "true" source of the Nile River, isolating the students from the rest of the country.

The student body is a microcosm of Rwandan society under the Hutu-dominated government. There is a strict **quota system**:

- The vast majority of students are **Hutu**, the daughters of powerful politicians, military officers, and businessmen.
- Only a tiny minority (two students in the main narrative) are **Tutsi**, allowed in merely to maintain a façade of fairness.

The school is meant to mold the future female elite of Rwanda—good wives and mothers for the ruling class—but it becomes a breeding ground for hatred.

II. Detailed Plot Summary

The narrative is episodic rather than following a single linear adventure, mirroring the slow, creeping accumulation of prejudice in daily life.

Life at the Lycée

The girls live under the strict supervision of the Mother Superior and the chaplain, **Father Herménégilde**. While they receive a Western, Catholic education, the atmosphere is suffocating. The Hutu girls, led by the militant **Gloriosa**, constantly assert their dominance, reminding the Tutsi girls of their precarious position.

The Influence of Fontenaille

Two Tutsi students, **Virginia** and **Veronica**, befriend an eccentric white plantation owner named **Monsieur de Fontenaille**. He is obsessed with the "Hamitic Myth"—the colonial theory that Tutsis are a superior race originating from Ancient Egypt or Ethiopia.

- Fontenaille sketches the girls and takes them to his run-down estate, which he has turned into a "museum" of Tutsi history.
- He shows them skeletons and ancient artifacts, treating them as specimens of a dying race rather than living teenagers.
- Veronica is entranced by his stories, but Virginia is wary, sensing the danger in being fetishized.

The Rising Tension

Gloriosa, the daughter of a high-ranking minister, begins a campaign to "purify" the school. She uses her father's influence to intimidate teachers and the Mother Superior.

- She spreads rumors that the Tutsi girls are poisoning the food or practicing witchcraft.
- She targets the school's statue of the Virgin Mary (Our Lady of the Nile). Gloriosa is angered that the statue has a straight, "Tutsi-like" nose. Under the guise of a project, she breaks the statue's nose and attempts to reshape it to look more Hutu, symbolizing the desire to erase Tutsi identity from the country's religious and cultural icons.

The Climax and Conclusion

The tension breaks when political unrest in the capital reaches the school. Taking advantage of the chaos, militants (the *Interahamwe* youth) arrive at the school.

- Gloriosa points out the Tutsi students to the soldiers.
 - A violent purge ensues. The Tutsi girls are hunted down.
 - Virginia manages to escape with the help of a sympathetic character, fleeing into the wilderness to survive.
 - The novel ends with a bleak atmosphere; the "cancer" of hatred has fully metastasized. The innocence of the school setting is shattered, foreshadowing the massacres to come in 1994.
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III. Character Analysis

1. Gloriosa (The Antagonist)

Gloriosa represents the **ideology of Hutu Power**. She is politically savvy, manipulative, and cruel. She does not just bully the Tutsi girls; she actively works to dehumanize them. She views herself as the defender of the "majority people" and uses the tools of the state (her father's power) to enforce her will within the school.

2. Virginia (The Survivor)

Virginia is the most grounded character. Unlike Veronica, she resists the allure of Fontenaille's colonial romanticism. She stays connected to her own intuition and traditional Rwandan beliefs (consulting a wise woman/healer). She represents the resilience and memory of the Tutsi people.

3. Veronica (The Victim of Exoticism)

Veronica is naive and becomes fascinated by Fontenaille. She allows herself to be defined by the "Hamitic" fantasy he projects onto her. She represents the danger of internalizing the colonizer's definition of oneself.

4. Father Herménégilde

The school chaplain represents the **complicity of the Catholic Church**. He is a hypocrite who preaches love but turns a blind eye to (and participates in) the persecution of Tutsis. He uses his spiritual authority to manipulate the girls and eventually aligns himself with the violent militia.

5. Monsieur de Fontenaille

A symbol of **Colonial Legacy**. He claims to love Tutsis, but his love is toxic. He views them as "living fossils" or aesthetic objects, not human beings. His obsession with their "noble origins" only fuels the resentment of the Hutu nationalists, inadvertently putting the girls in greater danger.

IV. Key Themes

1. The Roots of Genocide

Mukasonga shows that genocide does not happen overnight. It begins with language, exclusion, and education. The Lycée is a laboratory where the girls practice the hatred that will later destroy their country. The

quota system normalizes the idea that one group belongs and the other does not.

2. Colonialism and the Hamitic Myth

The novel critiques how Belgian colonizers classified Rwandans. The "Hamitic Myth" (that Tutsis were "black Europeans" from the Nile and therefore natural rulers) was used by colonizers to privilege Tutsis, and later by Hutu extremists to brand Tutsis as "foreign invaders" who should be sent back to the Nile (often via the river, as corpses).

3. The Female Body as a Battlefield

The girls are constantly scrutinized.

- **For Marriage:** They are commodities to be educated and married off to powerful men to secure alliances.
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- **For Race:** Their noses, height, and skin tone are measured to determine their ethnicity and worth. Gloriosa's attack on the statue's nose is a symbolic attack on the Tutsi female body.
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4. Religion: Catholicism vs. Tradition

The school imposes strict Catholicism, but beneath the surface, ancient Rwandan beliefs persist. The girls fear spirits and consult witch doctors. The "Virgin Mary" is a contested figure—is she the white colonizer's god, or can she belong to Rwanda?

V. Symbols

- **The Statue of Our Lady of the Nile:** Represents the soul of the country. By smashing its nose, Gloriosa attempts to rewrite history and claim divine favor exclusively for the Hutu majority.
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- **The Nile (The Source):** Represents the mythical origin. For Fontenaille, it is where the Tutsis came from (Egypt). For the Hutu extremists, it is where the Tutsis must be "returned" (dead).
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- **Rain/Mud:** The constant rain and the difficult terrain isolate the school, creating a claustrophobic atmosphere where violence can occur without witnesses.
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- **The Gorilla:** In one subplot, the girls encounter a gorilla. It represents the untamable, raw nature of the land that exists outside the rigid political and religious structures of the school.
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Why this book matters

Scholastique Mukasonga lost 27 members of her family in the genocide. *Our Lady of the Nile* is not just a story; it is an act of memory. It serves as a warning of what happens when a society teaches its children to hate.

Deep and clear light shedding on the Themes of *The Vandalism of the Statue* and *The Visit to Fontenaille's Plantation*.

Both scenes act as mirror images of each other. One represents the **violent erasure** of Tutsi identity (by Hutu Power ideology), while the other represents the **toxic fetishization** of it (by the Colonial Gaze).

1. The Vandalism of the Statue

The Context

The statue of the Virgin Mary, "Our Lady of the Nile," stands at a bend in the road near the school. It was erected during colonial times. Gloriosa, the militant Hutu student, becomes obsessed with the statue's nose. In the racial stereotyping of Rwanda, a thin, aquiline nose was associated with Tutsis, while a broad, flat nose was associated with Hutus.

The Scene

Gloriosa convinces her fearful friend Modesta to help her sneak out at night. She climbs the pedestal not to pray, but to inspect the face. She is outraged to find that the Virgin Mary has a "Tutsi nose." She declares that the Mother of God cannot belong to a "minority" race.

- **The Act:** Gloriosa tries to remodel the nose using tools to break off the tip and widen it, attempting to make the Virgin look "Hutu." In the process, she accidentally damages the face more than intended, leaving the statue disfigured.
- **The Cover-up:** She later claims the damage was a miracle or a sign, and eventually, the authorities decide to replace the head entirely.

Analysis & Symbolism

- **The Nose as a Political Symbol:** The obsession with the nose highlights the absurdity and danger of racial essentialism. In Rwanda, physical features were measured by colonizers to classify people; here, Gloriosa adopts that same colonial metric to justify exclusion.
- **Appropriation of Divinity:** By reshaping the Virgin, Gloriosa is asserting that God is on the side of the Hutu majority. It is an attempt to "nationalize" religion. If Mary is Hutu, then the persecution of Tutsis is divinely sanctioned.
- **Foreshadowing Violence:** The violence committed against the statue (chipping away at the face) is a rehearsal for the violence committed against human bodies later in the book. If one can mutilate a sacred icon to make it fit an ideology, mutilating people is the next logical step.

2. The Visit to Fontenaille's Plantation

The Context

Fontenaille is a white artist and coffee planter living in isolation near the school. He is obsessed with the "Hamitic Myth"—the discredited European theory that Tutsis were a lost Caucasian tribe from Ethiopia or Egypt. He befriends the two Tutsi students, Virginia and Veronica.

The Scene

The girls visit his dilapidated house, which he has turned into a shrine to a "lost civilization."

- **The "Museum":** Fontenaille shows them photographs of Tutsis from the 1930s, taken by anthropologists. He also keeps skulls and skeletons, measuring them to prove their "superior" cranial capacity.
- **The Fetish:** He tells Veronica that she looks exactly like an ancient Egyptian queen (Isis or Kandt). He dresses her in robes and asks to paint her. He does not see her as a teenager named Veronica; he sees her as a "living fossil," a remnant of a race he believes is doomed to extinction.
- **The Divergence:**
- **Veronica** is seduced by this narrative. Downtrodden at school, she loves being told she is basically royalty. She internalizes his delusion.
- **Virginia** is horrified. She recognizes the skeletons and the photos for what they are: death. She realizes that Fontenaille's interest is morbid. He loves them *because* he thinks they are dying out.

Analysis & Symbolism

- **The Colonial Gaze:** Fontenaille represents the Western anthropologist who treats Africans as specimens rather than humans. He claims to be an ally of the Tutsis, but his "support" is based on a racist fantasy that separates them from their fellow Rwandans.
- **The Danger of "Positive" Stereotypes:** Fontenaille praises Tutsis for being "tall," "elegant," and "rulers." These are the exact same stereotypes Gloriosa uses to hate them (calling them "arrogant invaders"). Mukasonga demonstrates that "positive" racism is just as dangerous as negative racism because it marks the target as "other."
- **The Living Dead:** Fontenaille's house is full of ghosts. By associating the girls with skeletons and ancient history, he symbolically buries them before they are even dead.

Comparison: Two Sides of the Same Coin

Feature	The Vandalism (Gloriosa)	The Plantation (Fontenaille)
Goal	To erase Tutsi features.	To highlight/exaggerate Tutsi features.
Method	Violence and brute force.	"Science," art, and seduction.
View of Tutsis	"Invaders" who must be removed.	"Noble savages" who are tragic relics.
Result	Dehumanization (Tutsis as enemies).	Dehumanization (Tutsis as objects).

Conclusion on these scenes

Scholastique Mukasonga uses these two moments to trap the Tutsi characters in a pincer movement. They cannot be safe at school because Gloriosa wants to destroy them for being Tutsi. They cannot be safe with Fontenaille because he only values them as exotic artifacts. There is no space left for them simply to be Rwandan girls.

What to keep in from the final chapters

My dear E-learning members, let's go through an analysis of the harrowing final chapters of *Our Lady of the Nile*, detailing how the simmering tensions finally explode into the militia attack on the school. This conclusion serves as a historical microcosm: it demonstrates how the school was a "training ground" for the genocide that would consume the entire country years later.

1. The Breach of Sanctuary

For most of the novel, the Lycée is a fortress. The high altitude and the walls are meant to protect the girls. However, in the final chapters, the outside world crashes in.

- **The Pretext:** Rumors of attacks by "Inyenzi" (a derogatory term for Tutsi rebels, meaning "cockroaches") circulate. The government uses this fear to justify a crackdown.

- **The Invasion:** Military trucks and young militiamen (the precursors to the *Interahamwe*) arrive at the school. They do not break in; they are **let in**. The Mother Superior, despite her strictness, is powerless or unwilling to stop the authority of the Hutu state. The sanctuary is violated not by force, but by bureaucratic complicity.

2. The Selection (The Role of Gloriosa)

This is the moment Gloriosa has been preparing for. She transitions from a school bully to an active collaborator in ethnic cleansing.

- **The List:** The militants do not know which girls are Tutsi by sight alone. They need an insider. Gloriosa provides the names. She points them out.
- **The Betrayal:** This scene destroys the idea of "sisterhood" within the school. The shared dormitory, once a place of whispers and secrets, becomes a hunting ground. Gloriosa's actions prove that ethnic loyalty trumps human connection or religious morality in this radicalized society.

3. The Complicity of the Church (Father Herménégilde)

Father Herménégilde reveals his true colors in these chapters. He is not a protector; he is a predator.

- **Spiritual Blackmail:** Throughout the book, he has used his position to sexually harass the girls. Now, he uses the threat of the militia to exert ultimate control.
- **The Exchange:** He implies that he can save the Tutsi girls if they submit to him sexually. When they refuse or when the violence spirals out of control, he abandons them to the militants. He represents the moral bankruptcy of the religious institutions that failed to stop the genocide in real life.

4. The Fates of Veronica and Virginia

The two Tutsi protagonists meet divergent fates, symbolizing two different tragic outcomes for the Tutsi people during this era.

Veronica: The Madness

Veronica, the girl fascinated by Fontenaille's colonial fantasies, faces a grotesque end.

- She is not killed immediately but is subjected to the brutality of the soldiers.

- Eventually, she is taken in by Monsieur de Fontenaille. However, this is not a rescue. Fontenaille keeps her in his "museum" house. Traumatized and broken, she becomes a living ghost, wandering his plantation like one of his ancient Egyptian queens. She descends into madness, totally disconnected from reality—a victim of both the Hutu violence and the white man's fetishization.

Virginia: The Escape

Virginia, who always distrusted Fontenaille and respected Rwandan traditions, survives by rejecting the school and the white man's world entirely.

- She flees the school grounds.
- **The Return to Tradition:** She seeks refuge not in a church or a colonial house, but in the wilderness, guided by the old woman/healer she visited earlier in the book.
- She survives by becoming invisible, blending into the land. This symbolizes that survival lay in reclaiming one's own identity and resilience, rather than relying on institutions (Church, State, or Colonizers) that were designed to destroy or exploit them.

5. The Chilling "Return to Normal"

The most disturbing part of the ending is not the violence itself, but what happens immediately after.

- The militia leaves. The Tutsi students are gone (dead, fled, or insane).
- The school reopens. The Hutu students return to their classes. Mass is held. Life goes on as if nothing happened.
- **The Message:** This silence is the loudest warning in the book. It normalizes the absence of the Tutsis. It teaches the Hutu girls that purging "undesirables" is a standard part of maintaining order.

Summary of the Ending

The end of *Our Lady of the Nile* is the death of innocence. The school, which was supposed to mold the "mothers of the nation," successfully molds them—but into mothers of a genocidal nation.

The novel closes with a sense of impending doom. While Virginia escapes, the reader knows that this is only **1979**. The true horror of 1994 is still to come, and the girls who watched their classmates be taken

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away will be the adults orchestrating or witnessing the apocalypse 15 years later.